CHAPTER 8

P A L E S T I N E A N D W O R L D J E W R Y

JEWISH DIVERSITY

To be a Jew today may mean much or almost nothing. It means, at the very least, to be identifiable as connected by family origin with an ancestor who professed the Jewish faith. To be a Jew does not, however, necessarily involve actual current adherence to the Jewish faith. To insist on a "religious test" would exclude from the Jewish population certainly many hundreds of thousands -- and perhaps millions -- of persons now universally regarded as Jews. This exclusion would affect important numbers not only in countries like the U.S.S.R. and the U.S.A. but also in Palestine. Present-day world Jewry is not a particularly religious group.

To be a Jew today may mean any degree of subjection to persecution or discrimination -- bodily torture and murder, denial of political equality, economic handicaps, social exclusion -- or it may mean complete assimilation to persons of other origin. To be a Jew may mean any degree of contamination by persecution and its psychological after-effects -- the consciousness of being arbitrarily treated as "different" and its resulting defensive and aggressive reactions. It is consistent also with any degree or direction of sublimation of the reactions originally produced by the consciousness of this arbitrary discrimination. Finally, to be a Jew is compatible with any position on the desirability of living in a Jewish national community oneself and every conceivable view of the wisdom of other Jews participating in the establishment of a Jewish national community.

In the five years 1939-44, about five million Jews have been killed or have lived in such conditions that they have failed to reproduce themselves. An especially large part of the Jewish population of eastern Europe has been destroyed. Jews of central and western Europe have also felt the lash of persecution and the hand of the executioner. Many Jews in countries untouched by Nazi occupation have been led to think of the insecurity in which hundreds